

Faith: The Vehicle God Uses to Impute Righteousness

Introduction

This discussion of salvation specifically pertains to justification—the act of God declaring sinners righteous through faith in Christ—rather than the ongoing process of sanctification or the future promise of glorification. While salvation encompasses all three, this study focuses on the imputation of righteousness at the moment of faith.

Faith as God's Delivery System

In theological terms, faith is the means or instrument of justification; in more illustrative terms, it may be understood as the vehicle or channel through which the righteousness of Christ is received.

Faith is the God-ordained means through which His righteousness is received by believers. Just as a pipeline transports water without creating it, or a courier delivers a package without producing its contents, faith serves as the channel through which Christ's righteousness is imputed. It does not generate righteousness but simply receives what God has provided.

Paul states in Romans 3:22 that righteousness is “through faith in Jesus Christ,” emphasizing that faith is the means—not the source—of righteousness. Without faith, the righteousness God provides in Christ is not received—not because of any insufficiency in Christ's atonement, but because God has ordained faith as the instrument through which His grace is received.

By making faith the means of justification, God ensures that salvation remains entirely a work of grace, excluding human merit. Faith does not manufacture righteousness but rests upon what Christ has accomplished, securing justification solely through God's provision.

The Mechanics of Imputed Righteousness

God's righteousness is not infused or developed within us but legally credited to our account. This aligns with biblical justification, where God declares sinners righteous based on faith in Christ. As Romans 4:3 states, Abraham's faith “was counted to him as righteousness,” not because faith itself was meritorious, but because it united him with the Righteous One.

At the moment of faith, a divine exchange occurs:

- Our sin is imputed to Christ (2 Corinthians 5:21: “For He made Him who knew no sin to be sin for us...”).
- Christ's righteousness is imputed to us, so God sees His perfect righteousness rather than our failures.

This imputation occurs through faith alone—not by works, law-keeping, or moral improvement. Faith is the bridge by which the believer receives what Christ has accomplished.

Faith as the Instrument of Union with Christ

Faith also serves as the instrument through which believers are united with Christ. Paul frequently refers to being “in Christ” (Romans 8:1; 2 Corinthians 5:17), signifying the believer’s union with Christ in His death, resurrection, and righteousness.

Faith, like a vehicle or channel, does not create the life it conveys. It receives what God has accomplished through Christ. Through faith, believers receive the benefits of His atoning work, including the imputation of His righteousness. Faith is the open door to our hearts—our will—through which we respond to Christ as He stands and knocks (Revelation 3:20).

Faith as Reliance on God's Promise

Faith rests upon God’s testimony. Romans 4:20-22 describes Abraham’s faith as unwavering reliance on God’s promise. Likewise, saving faith is not about striving but resting in Christ’s finished work. As Newell explains, faith is not believing God will act in the future but trusting that what He has declared is already true.

Faith as the Means, Not the Merit

Faith does not obligate God to save but serves as the means through which righteousness is received. Leon Morris clarifies that faith is a channel for salvation, not its cause. Faith is not an achievement but the open hand receiving grace.

William Newell further distinguishes between faith and trust. Faith accepts God’s testimony concerning Christ as true; trust is the personal reliance upon Christ that follows from believing that testimony. Trust relies upon Christ’s promises rather than upon human performance. Salvation therefore rests upon God’s provision in Christ, received by faith and relied upon in trust, not upon performing good deeds.

A Universal Offer of Salvation

Paul affirms in Romans 3:22-23 that righteousness is available “to all and on all who believe,” without distinction. Since all have sinned, all must receive righteousness the same way—through faith in Christ.

Spurgeon illustrates this by noting that if there were multiple gospels tailored to different people, confusion would arise. Instead, God provides one perfect remedy—Christ’s atonement—**sufficient for anyone who believes.**

Conclusion: The Gift of Righteousness Through Faith

Saving faith in Christ is not a work that earns salvation but the means by which God’s righteousness is imputed. It is believing in Christ’s finished work on Calvary, which justifies

believers. This righteousness is available to all, ensuring that justification remains entirely a work of divine grace rather than human effort.

By making faith the instrument—not the merit—of salvation, the gospel remains a message of grace, leaving no room for boasting—only for glorifying God for imputing His righteousness and granting the gift of eternal life.